

# 17 MASS MEDIA



*If you don't read the newspaper, you are uninformed.  
If you do read the newspaper, you are misinformed.*

*Author unknown, commonly attributed to Mark  
Twain or Thomas Jefferson*

*We have more media than ever and more technology in our lives. It's supposed to help us communicate, but it has the opposite effect of isolating us.*

*Tracy Chapman*

## □ VOCABULARY INPUT

Dealing with this topic you will come across the following vocabulary. Read it and look up the unknown words in your dictionary.

- **types of mass media:** radio, television, the press, the Internet
- **functions of mass media:** to inform, to educate, to entertain, to advertise, to influence
  - pros:* live broadcasting, current events and world affairs, breaking news
  - cons:* influential, creating pseudo-idols, lack of objectivity, hoaxes
- **radio:** objectivity, reputation, specialisations, broadcasting in different languages, programmes: (phone-ins, morning shows, news, weather forecast)
- **television:** public, commercial/non-commercial channels/stations
  - programmes:* news, cartoons, fairy tales, comedies, soap operas, thrillers, quizzes, science fiction, documentaries, romantic films, psychological films, detective films, historical films, horror films, sitcoms (situational comedy), commercials, the weather forecast, TV shows, talk shows, TV series, political debates, reality shows, sport tournaments/matches, TV contests
  - dangers of watching TV:* obsession, addiction, eyesight damage, prevention from doing sports and being fit, overeating, no reading, violence, reality vs. fiction, advertising, becoming a couch potato
- **press/print media:** magazines, newspapers (local/national), journals, periodicals, on-line editions
  - nationwide distribution, influential, a widely read paper, circulation of newspapers
  - daily/weekly/monthly/quarterly/annually
  - “quality papers” vs. “popular papers”
  - tabloid, broadsheets, supplements, special editions, current issue, economic periodicals, blogs
  - cover, the front page/the back page, headline, article, feature article, report, column, editorial, review, obituary
  - journalists: editor, reporter, columnist, paparazzo
- **the Internet:**
  - pros:* immediate access to current information, constant contact with people (writing e-mails), sending documents, buying things, booking hotels, reserving tickets, transferring money, finding life partners, chatting, joining different discussion groups, reading blogs, social networking sites (Facebook, Twitter...)
  - cons:* books replaced by book readers, computer viruses, lack of oral communication, uncensored web sites

## □ DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Before reading the text, discuss the following questions in class.

1. Which mass media do people use daily?
2. What types of print media are there? Which of them enjoy the greatest popularity?
3. What are your favourite TV stations? Why?
4. Why do journalists for some magazines/papers create stories with little credibility?
5. Which media, in your opinion, offer the highest objectivity and reliability for the public?
6. Do you believe everything that the media say? For example, possible terrorist attacks, the threat of natural disasters, drastic changes in weather, etc.
7. How does the Internet make our lives easier?
8. How should parents prevent their children from spending too much time in front of the television or overusing the Internet?
9. Are you addicted to using your computer? How much time do you spend using Facebook and on the Internet in general?
10. What are the possible risks of overusing mass media?

## □ TEXT

Read the texts below in silence. Check the meaning of the words in bold answer the questions below.

### TYPES OF MASS MEDIA AND THEIR FUNCTIONS

In modern society we **receive** most of our information through different types of mass media, such as **via** television, newspapers, from the radio and the Internet. Since these media **reach** a very large **audience**, they are called mass media. They **serve**, first of all, as sources of information. They allow us to **follow world affairs** soon after events have happened. In the case of **live broadcasting**, we learn about **current events** as they happen. Most people follow national and world news regularly so that they can be well-informed. In the case of catastrophes, such as earthquakes or terrorist attacks, the whole world follows the mass media to get the **latest** information. Many channels **broadcast breaking news** in such situations. Mass media do not only inform, but they also educate. Documentary programmes take us to places we would never have a chance to see and **provide** us with information that we would **otherwise** not know about. **Apart from** their informative and educative functions, the role of mass media is also to entertain. People like to relax watching films, **sitcoms**, **soap operas** or **series**; some prefer discussions or reality shows; some like watching football or hockey matches. For many people TV and the Internet are the only ways they have of entertaining themselves.

1. What do you understand by the term "mass media"?
2. What are the functions of mass media? Support your explanation with examples from the text above.

## RADIO

There are several radio stations broadcasting in Slovakia. For example, *Fun Radio* addresses a wide audience with the music, news and discussions that they broadcast. *Express Radio* provides its listeners with traffic information every 20 minutes. *Radio Slovakia International* broadcasts in Slovak, English, German, French, Russian and Spanish. The other stations **specialise in** certain types of music, news, culture, religion or **cater for** minorities.

In Britain, radio and television broadcasting is provided by *BBC (British Broadcasting Corporation)*, which has a high international **reputation** for its objectivity. **Besides** the BBC, there are also other radio and TV broadcasters. The BBC has five national radio programmes and several television channels. The BBC's five programmes for radio broadcasting have their specialisations. The famous *BBC World Service* broadcasts across the world in English and many other languages, including Slovak.

There are a **variety** of different types of radio and TV stations in the USA. Most non-commercial radio stations are public and educational stations which are **operated** by colleges and universities and by various religious groups. Hundreds of radio stations in the USA broadcast in languages other than English for minorities speaking languages, such as Chinese, French, Japanese, Polish and Portuguese. About 160 radio stations **throughout** the USA broadcast only in Spanish.

3. Name three examples of radio stations in Slovakia and say what they broadcast.
4. What does BBC stand for and why is it so popular?
5. In which languages do radio stations broadcast in the USA?

## TELEVISION

*Slovak television* and *Slovak radio* have recently **merged** creating one public-service organisation called *Radio and Television Slovakia (RTVS)*. *STV1*, a television channel, broadcasts mostly news, political discussions, films, series and children programmes. *STV2* specialises in documentaries, **quiz shows**, educational programmes and music. It also broadcasts live football or hockey matches. Foreign language films on Slovak TV channels are mostly **dubbed**, rarely **subtitled**. Commercial stations, such as *TV Markíza* and *TV Joj*, also enjoy wide popularity. Popular series, sitcoms, quiz shows and reality shows also form a part of their programme. The introduction of **people-meters increased the competition** among the channels. *TA3*, the first Slovak news channel, broadcasts current news throughout the whole day. Its programmes **cover a wide range of** topics, such as economy, politics, show business, technology, sport, health care, etc. Apart from these channels, there are **local** channels which focus on local interests. Some TV stations have a selected number of their programmes **available** on their **websites**.

**Unlike** many other countries, the USA does not have a national broadcast service. There are hundreds of local TV stations. The five most popular seem to be: *Fox*, *CNN*, *NBC* and *ABC*. *CNN* is a news channel well-known across the world. In 1991, it was the only channel to be sending in reports of the Persian Gulf War as it was happening. It also **broke the devastating news of** the attack on the Twin Towers by plane **hijackers**. *CNN* is also

famous for hosting the "Larry King Live Show" which attracts nearly 1 million viewers an episode.

6. Which are the most popular Slovak TV channels? What do they specialise in? Use information from the text above.
7. What made CNN well-known across the world? Refer to the text above.

## NEWSPAPERS

In Slovakia, most newspapers are **daily newspapers**. They are **aimed at** certain social classes with a certain education and political orientation. *SME* and *Pravda* are daily papers with **nationwide distribution** that are **widely read** and **influential**. The best selling daily, however, is the **tabloid** *Nový Čas* whose **supplements** "*Nový čas víkend*" and "*Nový čas pre ženy*" have become very popular. Economic **periodicals** include the daily *Hospodárske noviny* and a **weekly** called *Trend*. *The Slovak Spectator* is a weekly English language newspaper providing information about Slovakia. Most of the newspapers now have their online **editions**. Besides these, there are many weekly and monthly lifestyle magazines for men, women and teenagers, for people interested in sports, gardening, cars, etc.

The British communication media, press, broadcasting and TV are among the most influential in the world. There are the **quality** daily **papers** or **broadsheets**: *The Times*, *The Guardian*, *The Financial Times*, *The Independent* and *The Daily Telegraph* which **contain** a wide variety of national and international news, **reports** from parliamentary debates, **reviews** of the arts, **features** about fashion and sport and business news. Nearly all the papers **pay special attention to** the reporting of sports, which play an important role in British life. Then there are papers with a high **circulation**, such as *The Daily Mirror* and *The Sun*, which are "popular papers" or tabloids. They rarely publish any serious material. The articles mostly deal with scandals involving famous people.

The largest daily newspapers published in the USA are *The Wall Street Journal*, *The New York Times*, *The Washington Post*, *New York Daily News*, *USA Today* and *The New York Post*. All of these are very serious "quality papers". *New York Post*, *the Daily News* and *the Metro* are **nationally recognised** tabloids that focus on the scandals of celebrities and stars.

8. Which are the most popular newspapers and magazines published in Slovakia? Describe them.
9. Which are the most famous quality dailies published in Britain and the USA?
10. In general, what do tabloids focus on? Name some tabloids published in Slovakia, Britain and the USA.

## THE INTERNET

The Internet presents a true revolution in many areas of our lives. It has changed the way we study, work, entertain and communicate. It has made **access to** any type of information easier. Nowadays, we do not have to use the phone anymore to find out about

train timetables, opening hours or details about products or services. We do not depend on **encyclopaedias** or dictionaries to find information. Internet **search engines**, online books and dictionaries are gradually **replacing** them. **Via the Internet** we send documents, buy things, book hotels, reserve tickets, transfer our money or find life partners. Many people use the Internet as a form of entertainment. Chatting, joining different discussion groups and reading **blogs** is becoming very popular, especially among the young. Access to the Internet at work, schools and at home has already become a normal part of our lives. There are many discussions that **concern** the **safety** of personal information and the safety of bank transfers. Many hackers get into different computer systems and misuse the **data**. They also create computer **viruses** which can **destroy** the data completely.

11. According to the text, how has the Internet changed our lives?
12. Why is Internet safety being discussed?

### NEGATIVE IMPACT OF MASS MEDIA ON PEOPLE

Despite the informative, educational and entertainment functions of the mass media, it may also **have a negative impact on** young people's mental development. There are children and young people who are **obsessed with** using the Internet and watching the TV for several hours a day. It is not healthy to **either** their mental **or** physical development. **Overusing** these media causes **damage to our eyesight** and can lead to a habit of overeating. They also prevent people from doing sports, being outside and reading books. Direct communication with each other is also **weakened**. Many parents do not have time for their children and TV and computers are ways of "**solving**" this problem. It is a well-known fact that violence in films influences children and the young in a very negative way. Children also sometimes have problems differentiating between **fiction** and reality. Some programmes, such as reality shows, create different **pseudo-idols** and present money or physical beauty as having the highest **value** in life. Some Internet sites are absolutely **inappropriate** for children. Therefore, their choice should be under parents' control. **All in all**, the media, which provides us with such a **vast range** of information, influence us and **shapes** our opinions to a great **extent**. We should stay objective and keep our own opinions.'

13. Why might overusing the Internet and TV have a negative impact on the mental and physical development of young people?
14. According to the text, direct communication among people is weakened due to the overuse of the Internet. Explain.

## □ VOCABULARY LIST

**access to** [ækses] – prístup k  
**to aim at** – zamerať sa na  
**all in all** – vcelku  
**apart from** – okrem  
**audience** – publikum  
**available** – k dispozícii  
**besides** – okrem  
**blog** – internetový denník, v ktorom autor pravidelne vyjadruje svoje názory na rôzne témy  
**breaking news** – mimoriadne správy  
**to broadcast** – vysielat'  
**broadsheet (quality paper)** – seriózna tlač  
**to cater for** [keɪtə(r)] – starať sa o  
**circulation** – náklad  
**to concern** – týkať sa  
**to contain** – obsahovať  
**current event** [kʌrənt] – aktuálna udalosť  
**daily newspaper** – denník  
**data** [deɪtə, also daɪtə] – dáta, údaje  
**to destroy** – zničiť  
**dubbed** [dʌbd] – dabovaný  
**edition** – vydanie  
**either... or** – buď... alebo  
**encyclopaedia** [ɪnsaɪklə'pi:diə] – encyklopédia  
**extent** – rozsah  
**feature** – článok, reportáž  
**fiction** – fikcia  
**hijacker** [haɪdʒækə(r)] – únosca  
**influential** [ɪnflu'ɛnʃl] – vplyvný  
**inappropriate** – nevhodný  
**latest** – najnovší  
**live broadcasting** [laɪv] – vysielanie naživo  
**local** [ləʊkl] – miestny  
**to merge** [mɜ:ʒ] – splynúť  
**nationally recognised** – celonárodne uznávaný  
**nationwide distribution** – celoštátna distribúcia  
**obsessed (with)** – posadnutý  
**to operate** – prevádzkovať  
**otherwise** – inak  
**to overuse** – nadmerne používať  
**to pay attention to** – venovať pozornosť  
**people-metre** – píplmeter, spôsob merania sledovanosti televízie  
**periodical** – časopis  
**to provide** [prə'vaɪd] – poskytnúť

**pseudo-idol** [sju:dəʊ, also su:dəʊ aɪdl] – pseudoidol  
**quiz show** – televízny kvíz, súťaž  
**to reach** – dosiahnuť  
**to receive** – dostať  
**to replace** – nahradiť  
**report** – záznam, reportáž  
**reputation** – povesť  
**review** – recenzia, kritika  
**safety** – bezpečnosť  
**search engine** – internetový vyhľadávací systém  
**series** [sɪəri:z] – televízny seriál  
**to serve as** – slúžiť ako  
**to shape** – formovať  
**sitcom** – situačná komédia  
**soap opera** – romantický televízny seriál (telenovela)  
**to solve** – riešiť  
**to specialise in** – špecializovať sa na  
**subtitled** [sʌbtartld] – s titulkami (film)  
**supplement** – príloha  
**tabloid** – bulvárne noviny  
**throughout** [θru:'aʊt] – po celom  
**unlike** – odlišne  
**value** – hodnota  
**variety** [və'raɪəti] – rôzne druhy  
**vast range** – široká škála  
**via** [vaɪə] – prostredníctvom  
**virus** [vaɪrəs] – vírus  
**to weaken** – oslabiť  
**weekly (newspaper)** – týždenník (noviny)  
**to break the devastating news of** – prinášať zničujúce správy o  
**to cover a wide range (of)** – zahrnúť širokú škálu  
**to damage one's eyesight** [aɪsaɪt] – poškodiť si zrak  
**to follow world affairs** – sledovať svetové dianie  
**to have a negative impact on** – mať negatívny dopad na  
**to increase the competition** – zvýšiť konkurenciu  
**via the Internet** – cez, prostredníctvom internetu  
**widely read** – veľmi čítaný

## □ VOCABULARY PRACTICE

### Task 1 Which types of mass media do the following definitions describe?



1. A machine which receives and sometimes broadcasts sounds. r\_\_\_\_\_o
2. A machine which can show pictures on a screen. t\_\_\_\_\_n
3. Software which allows users to make phone calls over the Internet. s\_\_\_\_\_e
4. The electronic network of connected computers. the I\_\_\_\_\_t
5. A station which broadcasts TV programs. c\_\_\_\_\_l
6. A weekly or monthly publication with pictures, stories and articles. m\_\_\_\_\_e
7. A publication printed daily or weekly containing news. n\_\_\_\_\_r
8. A "popular paper" with local stories, scandals and entertainment. t\_\_\_\_\_d
9. A journalist's article on TV or in print. r\_\_\_\_\_t
10. A "quality paper" which contains a wide variety of national and international news, reports from parliamentary debates, reviews of the arts, features about fashion and sport and business news. b\_\_\_\_\_t

### Task 2 Which programmes from the list below would children/teenagers/older people NOT BE INTERESTED in watching? Why?

news cartoons – fairy tales – comedies – soap operas – thrillers – quizzes – science fiction – documentaries – historical films – horror films – sitcoms (situational comedies) – commercials – weather forecast – TV shows – talk shows – TV series – reality shows – sport tournaments/matches – TV contests

children: .....

teenagers: .....

older people: .....

## □ REVIEW

**Task 11** What is the difference in meaning between the following words?  
If you are not sure, check the meaning in your dictionary.

- |                                         |                              |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------|
| a) quality papers/popular papers        | e) channel/programme/station |
| b) a paper/some paper                   | f) sitcom/soap opera/series  |
| c) editor/journalist/reporter/paparazzo | g) dubbed/subtitled          |
| d) review/report/column/blog            | h) viewer/audience           |

**Task 12** Look at the pictures of different newspapers and magazines below. Decide which type of papers/magazines they are (daily/weekly/monthly/periodicals/"quality papers"/"popular papers", etc.) and what kind of articles you would expect to find there. Where are they published? Who are their readers? Check with information on the Internet.

